



## **CHAPTER IV**

### **FORT LOUISA AND COAL CREEK**

#### **1851**

On Monday April 7, 1851, the fifteen lead wagons of a large California bound company, led by Parley P. Pratt and Charles C. Rich arrived in Fort Louisa. This group, who was commissioned by the First Presidency to travel to the Pacific Ocean on a mission to its islands and coasts, had left Salt Lake in March with several men and some of their wives. They journeyed most of the way with a large company of Saints, outfitted with 150 wagons, who were emigrating with Charles C. Rich and Amasa Lyman to southern California. On Sunday, April 13, 1851, the party stayed at Fort Louisa and attended worship services, where they and the settlers received encouragement and counsel from the two apostles, Pratt and Rich. Pratt admonished them to stay and help build up the settlement, knowing that some had left Salt Lake City against the counsel of the L.D.S. Presidency. A few of the main company came to settle in Fort Louisa but most were continuing on, and George A. Smith was surprised to see some of his acquaintances moving to California. The visitors created great interest among the settlers. It was very unusual for a company of this magnitude to come through the settlement.

Apostles Pratt and Rich went on to Summit Creek on Monday, April 14, and the following Sunday most of the settlers from Fort Louisa traveled there for another good meeting with these men.

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President George A. Smith, who also took part in the meeting, rode part way in John D. Lee's carriage. However, the horses became uneasy and caused one of the reins which controlled the bit to break, and the carriage tipped over. This made it necessary to return to the fort and get another wagon. There were several passengers in the carriage, including sisters Lee and Smith, and according to Smith: "They were very bruised and looked as if they had had a good beating, but they continued on." Many of the brethren walked to Summit for the meeting. Lunt and his companion, Brother Wiley, went on foot.<sup>1</sup> At the end of the meeting P. B. Lewis, a local resident, was set apart as one of the Pacific missionaries, and he and his wife left with the group that afternoon. That day Parley P. Pratt recorded the following in his journal:

We traveled eight miles to a stream called Coal Creek. Encamped and built a bridge across the deep and narrow channel, and tarried here next day waiting for the remainder of our company, some of whom had failed to obtain their animals the day before. This stream forms a rich meadow bottom of about fifteen miles long and two broad. Abundance of Cedar fuel and rich pasturage is found on the table lands which border this bottom, and iron ore abounds a few miles to the southwest, not to mention a large cottonwood grove in the upper part of the meadow, and a canyon opening into the mountains from which the stream issues. Taken all together, this place combines materials for a large settlement.<sup>2</sup>

The association and meeting with Pratt and the other apostles gave the settlers of Fort Louisa renewed faith to continue in their efforts. Henry Lunt felt the Spirit which was poured out in abundance in the meetings, and he was even more convinced of the truthfulness of the Gospel. After the apostles and their companies left, everyone went back to their usual schedules. The following week George A. Smith wrote:

On Friday, April 25, laid hands on Sister Miller who had just become the mother of a fine daughter, the fourth child born in our new town, and without the aid of doctor or midwife, as our county does not afford any such professional characters. During the forepart of the night it rained several hours beautifully.

Monday April 28: Brother Shepherd this morning, with four others, reported the death of Sister Swartout and asked for lumber to make a coffin. Brother Whitney found some, taking part of a wagon bed which he used for a floor. I selected a place for a burying ground northeast of Louisa in a cedar grove. Attended the burying about 3 o'clock. She died at the crossing at Cottonwood, age 22 years, leaving a child three days old.<sup>3</sup>

Some of the men, who were exploring the creek at Cottonwood, found some stone coal which had washed down from the canyon. On May 3, two men who were exploring Cottonwood Canyon (Cedar Canyon) reported two veins of coal were exposed due to a landslide which took place four miles up the canyon. Brother Whitney tried the coal in his forge and was able to make horseshoe nails and weld pieces of iron together. He pronounced that it was a good quality. However, President Smith stated: "It will cost two thousand dollars or one thousand days' work to make a road to the coal."<sup>4</sup> On May 7, Smith sent Brothers Frost, Bringhurst and Green to Iron Springs to procure some specimens of iron ore, and he and Brother Farr rode their horses in search of a site for a city. Smith wrote: "Found a splendid site on both sides of Coal Creek. [The creek] is a rod wide, 15 inches deep, very rapid stream, rocky bed, soft water, milk water color, banks covered with scrub cedars and a few serviceberry bushes, some Spanish soap root, and abundant grass--all five miles from coal and ten miles from iron--and large tracts of farming land. This point must become a fine flourishing manufacturing town."

Henry Lunt wrote: "May 10: Snow fell this morning six inches deep. President Brigham Young and company (about forty people)

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arrived at our camp. We fired the cannon six times in welcome." President Young spent the next few days visiting the settlers and giving comforting instructions to those who wanted to go home. He and others in the party visited the gristmill and spent a day at Red Creek (Paragonah) where a few families had settled. On Thursday, May 15, they rode to Summit Creek and on south over the divide and viewed Coal Creek or Iron Valley. They were all delighted with the prospect of a settlement at that location.<sup>5</sup>

On Friday they met in a council and organized the city of Parowan which they felt was a better name than Fort Louisa. William H. Dame was unanimously elected as Mayor assisted by Aldermen: Richard Harrison, Tarlton Lewis, John D. Lee, and Mathew Carruthers. Also elected were the following Councillors: Andrew A. Love, Joel Johnson, Dr. William Moss, William Layney, Dr. Briddy Meeks, Elijah Newman, Robert Wiley, John Wolf, and John Dalton. A week later on Saturday, May 24, the Council met in the Council House and chose men for several other positions. Henry Lunt was appointed as Treasurer.

After organizing Parowan and giving some excellent instructions on government, Brigham Young and his party started on their return journey on Friday, May 16. Brother Hofheins saluted them with three discharges from the cannon as they rode out of the fort. The group planned to camp at Red Creek that evening. About 28 men from Parowan accompanied Young on his return home, some of them to get their families and some to attend to business in Salt Lake City.

A few days later when Bishop Tarlton Lewis was exploring around Red Creek, he discovered a large mound of dirt. When he dug into it, he found an adobe wall, timber, and what he thought to be some human bones and hair. The next day President Smith and Brother Bayles and their wives went to examine the ruins and found more than 120 mounds in the vicinity, the largest measuring 88 by 78 yards. They came to the conclusion that these were ruins of an Indian city. The dwellings were composed of dirt with roofs of earth supported by timbers which had decayed, causing a hollow at the top of each dwelling. They found very solid adobes, charcoal, kernels of corn, many pieces of pottery and bones of animals, but they felt sure there

were no human bones.<sup>6</sup>

The water from Center Creek washed out the headgate at the mill race on Friday, May 30. In addition to the water problems, the cattle were destroying the wheat because of inadequate fences. President Smith gave notice that, beginning Saturday, all the men in the camp would be required to build and repair the fences around the fields. The settlers needed a road built from Red Creek to Coal Creek, so on June 2, the court appointed a County Commissioner and a Supervisor of Roads, and they were instructed to locate a suitable route.

The following journal entries were written by George A. Smith:

Monday, June 9, 1851: General cattle drive. Brother Goodale had an ox come up badly shot with arrows. The heads of two cattle were found and quite a number of cattle were missing, also a horse.

Wednesday, June 11: Called the brethren together and advised them to gather their horses and loose cattle and to put them in the general herd or they would be liable to be stolen or killed by the Indians.

Thursday, June 12: Several Parvine Indians came into camp this morning with a letter from John D. Lee who had left earlier in the week for Salt Lake. They also brought a horse taken by them from the Utes which the Utes had stole from Brother Bozarth in the spring. They said the horse's mate had been killed and eaten by the Utes. Brother Bozarth paid the Indians for bringing the horse.

The weather had been very warm and dry with temperatures over 90 degrees, and the water in the creeks was getting low. The men began investigating ways to dig canals from Center Creek, Red Creek, and Summit Creek to water their crops. A company of twenty wagons arrived in Parowan on Friday, June 27, 1851, bringing the families of some of the men who had been sent with the first company. They brought letters and newspapers to most of the settlers. Brother Pugmire brought a package and some letters to George A. Smith.

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One of the letters was written to inform him that his wife, Sarah Ann, had died of consumption.<sup>7</sup> The latest Washington paper was dated April 13. Henry received a letter from Martha Bristol in England, dated February 22, 1851. She wrote:

My Dearest Henry: Your letters do indeed bring peace to my mind and joy to my soul, and for such blessings how can I sufficiently thank you. Although we are, at present, divided by a distance of ten thousand miles, my feelings have been such that the greater the distance the more firm and sincere my affections have grown. Who can tell but our separation may still be for years; but, if even so, I am thine forever and thine alone. I kindly thank you for the cheering hopes you give me of the happy return (by the blessing of God) being sooner than we may perhaps expect, but whether or not, dear Henry, I do not murmur or repine, knowing and feeling that if we both continue faithful in the Lord all will work together for good, both for our temporal and eternal welfare.

I am very comfortable at this quiet and retired spot and do think I never enjoyed such good health in all my life. Dearest Henry, I am still your faithful friend. It is true as you say I have had a deal to contend with so to remain, but I feel so fully convinced that your opinions are right, all England could not persuade me to the contrary. I devote what leisure time I have to reading the books you were so kind as to send me, which help to increase my faith on the important subject, and I am anxiously looking forward to the happy time when we shall both walk hand in hand together in the path of life.

I will write to you again shortly and conclude my present letter with affectionate love and constant prayer for your welfare and happiness, and believe me

to be . . . Yours forever faithfully and affectionately,  
Martha Bristol<sup>8</sup>

Henry managed to focus his mind on the things at hand, since he was so busy working with the settlers to build a community. He toiled in the fields every day until the last rays of sun disappeared. Consequently, each evening after he had eaten and written in George A. Smith's journal and in the camp log he fell exhausted into bed. This letter, however, undoubtedly brought renewed thoughts of the girl in England whom he had long loved and he would surely not be separated from except for his strong beliefs. This letter seemed to indicate that Martha was beginning to be converted to the teachings of the L.D.S. Church. If only he could return for a time and help convince her. In spite of his feelings of loneliness, he looked forward to his future in America among the Saints and didn't have any regrets.

The crops were flourishing in spite of the hot and dry weather. The settlers turned the water into the finished canal on July 3, 1851. The ground was so dry that the water made very slow progress. The settlers worked diligently to improve their environment and to explore the surrounding territory for more convenient travel routes. Two men, Shirts and Gould, reported an excellent route to the Beaver area which could be traveled without a mountain to cross, however the cost to build a road would be almost prohibitive.

The Saints placed much more emphasis on celebrating the 24th of July than they did on July 4th, Independence Day. Smith wrote: "July 4: All was silent, not a gun fired nor a drunken man seen in the streets. July 6: I went to the water and baptized four persons. July 8: We organized a police force. Sunday, July 13: Fine shower in the morning—laid the dust." Lunt wrote the following entry in his journal on Sunday, July 20, 1851:

This day I am 27 years old. I return thanks to my heavenly father for his protecting care over me on my perilous voyage to this land, and that I am a member of His church. May my life still be preserved and prolonged that I may continue to throw in my might

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towards building up the Church and Kingdom of God. On July 24th the flag was raised and the cannon fired and, this being the day the pioneers arrived in Great Salt Lake Valley, we had a celebration. The cannon was fired, had a fine procession, marched to the Bowery where all assembled. Some appropriate hymns and songs were sung and some good speeches were made. Concluded with a ball in the evening at Brother Shirt's house. All enjoyed themselves and good will prevailed.<sup>9</sup>

In the program Henry sang a solo, entitled "Old Adam Was a Gentleman."

The first marriage in Iron County took place on July 29, 1851, when George A. Smith married Robert Callisby to Phoebe Dart. It was noted that the girl was of age and she married contrary to her father's wishes.

Smith wrote the following entries in his journal: "July 28: I employed Joseph Claws to build an ash house and privy containing an apartment for chickens. Wednesday, July 30: Brother Webb made me a door and some shelves for my books. A good many of the brethren are busy getting hay and harvesting some early patches of grain."

By this time the food, originally brought by the settlers, was getting very scarce. There had been a few shipments of flour from Salt Lake, but there would be no vegetables until the gardens began to produce. Smith noted on August 2, that he had a mess of new potatoes and obtained fifteen pounds of beef which added very much to the scanty variety of bread and water. The women learned to use every method possible in preparing different types of bread and pastries from flour. Smith wrote that his wife, Zilpha, was a good cook who baked corn meal pones in a bake kettle and fried doughnuts in a little three-legged skillet.<sup>10</sup> Many years went by before she had a cook stove in her house.

On August 4, the voting polls opened at 10 a.m., after the firing of the cannon to announce election day. The following candidates were put in by unanimous vote: John M. Bernisel--delegate to Congress,

George A. Smith--delegate to Territorial Council, and Elisha H. Groves--Representative to the Legislature. The City Council met and passed an ordinance for the prevention of fires within the Fort. A company of settlers met to make arrangements to return to the Great Salt Lake for Conference, and a dance was held that evening at the Parowan House.

Smith wrote: "August 7: It rained very heavily near Red Creek. A thunder cloud burst on the mountain up Dry Creek and raised Center Creek one foot. The water which was as red as blood flooded Parowan." The settlers had been allowing the Indians to work in the fields and glean some of the wheat for their own use. The quorum met on Sunday, August 10, and decided against this practice. President Smith, who was not present due to illness, rescinded this decision that evening. He told the brethren that President Young had counseled them to employ the Indians such as were willing to work.<sup>11</sup>

The settlers not only kept busy working in the fields and harvesting crops, but they continued building on the homes, fences, corrals, and other buildings. Smith spent the day of August 12th finishing his chicken coop. That day, Henry gave him a fine sage hen to eat. Peter Shirts built a second story on Smith's house (Parowan House). Smith left for Salt Lake City leaving Bishop Elisha Groves in charge during his absence. While he was gone, Henry and some of the brethren hauled several loads of hay for him. A company of people in six wagons left Parowan on August 21, 1851, to attend conference in Salt Lake City. Brother Wiley, the man who was living with Henry, went with the group.

The months of September and October were spent in the same fashion, working diligently to harvest crops and get prepared for winter. A rich harvest of grain, potatoes, squash, and vegetables was the result of their toil. According to an account written by Andrew Jenson: "A grist and sawmill combined were erected, lumber of the finest quality was supplying our wants, and when flour was wanted we had to turn the bolt [in the mill] by hand until our immediate wants were satisfied. Later additional machinery was added."<sup>12</sup>

George A. Smith conducted a survey for the location of an iron manufacturing colony at Coal Creek (Cedar City) in November 1851.

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He wrote the following, dated November 5, to the *Deseret News*:

Yesterday a site was surveyed for a fort and stock corral on Coal Creek, twenty miles from Parowan. Today a company has been organized to commence operations immediately in the construction of this new post. They are mostly composed of English, Scotch, and Welsh miners and iron manufacturers. They have been organized into two companies of militia, one a horse and the other foot, which form the Second Battalion of Iron County. The company are all in fine spirits. They will commence on Monday to put up their corral, after which they will move their families which are remaining here, and encamp in their corral until their fort is completed. They have a beautiful situation.

Smith was unanimously elected Colonel of the Militia. John D. Lee stated in a letter to Brigham Young: "On November 5th, the militia of Coal Creek was organized into a regiment. Quite a feeling is up for the Coal Creek settlement in so much that but little is said about settling the Rio Virgin area."<sup>13</sup> That same day Lunt was promoted to Captain of the Iron County Regiment. It indicated on the roster that this regiment was part of the Nauvoo Legion. Lunt was given a rifle, one powder horn, two pounds of rifle powder, and five pounds of lead.<sup>14</sup>

The Parowan Ward minutes contained the following information written on November 10, 1851: "A company of 35 men with 11 wagons, from Parowan, under the charge of Henry Lunt as president, started for Coal Creek to form a settlement, arriving at their destination on the 11th, and at once beginning their labor on the fort." Lunt wrote that they camped on Summit Creek and continued on to Coal Creek the next day, arriving at 4 p.m. Having thus launched the final phase of the Iron Mission which he was called to direct, George A. Smith left Iron County. Through his continued contacts with Iron County and Utah's south land he became known as the "Iron Colonel"

and father of the southern Utah colonies.

Up until this time Henry Lunt had probably not been entirely sure of his place in the new community. Not being married and without an immediate need for a home, he had spent his time helping others on the fields and fencing. He had planted his own garden on the property that he had been allotted and had reaped a fairly good harvest. His interests had been directed towards the production of iron all along, and when the decision came to begin a fort nearer to the iron and coal, he was ready and willing to go. Now he could build a house on Coal Creek and work towards the manufacturing of iron. This surely was a satisfying turn of events which gave his life new meaning.

1. Henry Lunt, "Henry Lunt Journal," (Provo, Utah: B.Y.U. Library, Copied from original journal 1955) p. 47.
2. Parley Pratt, *Parley P. Pratt*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Deseret Book Company 1938), p. 376.
3. George A. Smith, "George A. Smith Journal," (Provo, Utah: B.Y.U. Library, Copied from original manuscript, 1956), p. 57.
4. *Ibid.*, p. 61.
5. *Ibid.*, p. 63.
6. *Ibid.*, p. 66.
7. *Ibid.*, p. 72.
8. Vern and Rachel Petty Lunt, *The Life of Henry Lunt*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: 1944), p. 75.
9. Henry Lunt, *op. cit.*, p. 48.
10. George A. Smith, *op. cit.*, p. 77.
11. *Ibid.*, p. 78.
12. Andrew Jenson, *L.D.S. Journal History*, Entry for Oct 1851, Film Number CRMH 1514.
13. Andrew Jenson, *L.D.S. Journal History*, Letter from John D. Lee to Brigham Young, dated November 5, 1851.
14. "Muster Roll of Company B, Nauvoo Legion" (State of Utah: Division of Archives).